# DEPENDENT ON EXPERIENCE



# Tales for an accelerated workforce

Dear --------

We would like to invite you to contribute to our event 'Dependent On Experience: Tales for an Accelerated Workforce', as part of the Antiuniversity Now festival on 15 June 2017. We plan to host a conversation on the theme of creative work, from 7.30–9.30pm with time to informally chat after over some drinks. It would be great if you could give a small introduction to yourself/group/project in relation to the theme. Please see www.antiuniversity.org/Thursday-15-June-2017/Dependent-On-Experience-Tales-for-an-Accelerated-Workforce for a description of the event.

The event (and Antiuniversity generally) is organised on a voluntary basis, and unfortunately there is no fee available to pay ourselves or contributors. Instead, we can offer a skills or time exchange in return for your labour. This could include anything from free use of the Evening Class space, or design/other services provided by members of EC. The alternative we are offering reflects the importance of reciprocal labour exchange – and goes some way to advocating exchanges that go beyond remuneration and promote meaningful exchange between individuals.

All the best,
Evening Class




"What I am proposing is that the work ethic (To either find a master to employ you for wages, or live in squalid poverty) is obsolete..."
(Robert Anton Wilson, author, voodoo priest and former editor of PLAYBOY)

Towards the end of 1982 I joined an American organization called the Church of the Sub-Genius, a crank cult based in Austin, Texas. It was easy; all I had to do was send off the equivalent of 10 dollars and in return I recieved a membership certificate and a huge bale of propaganda material. I am now an ordained priest (true) entrusted to perform all the duties of the sub-Genius ministry, including sermons, invocations, exorcisms, marriages, sacrifices, seances, miracles, insane phenomena, alien contact, smitings, deflowerings and the acceptance of donations.

The people who run the church are very straightfaced about it. They never come out and admit that it's all a joke, because that would spoil the fun. But it is a joke - a damned good one. And like all good jokes, it contains an element of truth. For instance, one of the Church's pamphlets criticises ordinary men and women who spend their lives "wading uphill through mud, desperately hacking out with a broken machete little short lived clearings in the social swamp - working, in effect, until it's too late to stop working."

This is what most people do - they work until it's too late to stop working, wasting most of their time and energy and very frequently doing serious damage to their health in the service of distant figures.

Very few people in public life have ever questioned this state of affairs. In fact, Malcolm McLaren is the only one who springs to mind. When he launched Bow-wow-wow onto an unsuspecting world, he made a great song and dance about 'breaking down the work ethic'. Now I regard the dreaded Talcy Malcy, as he's known to NME readers far and wide, as nothing more than a nasty, manipulative little con-man. He's engineered several 'musical movements' over the past five years, and they've all been publicity hypes designed to promote Viv Westwood's fashions. As Dave Barbe put it "If the truth's supposed to go naked, how come McLaren's so into the rag trade?" The Pistols were a vehicle for her 'punk' designs; Bow-wow-wow were a vehicle for her Bucaneer look, and the new She Sherrif/ Buffalo Gals thing is a transparent attempt to shift more of her bloody ridiculous cowboy/hillbilly clothes (that she did'nt even come up with first!) Still, Malcy does occasionally come up with a good line or slogan, and this business about 'breaking down the work ethic' was one of them. "There's no need to work, ever/ W.O.R.K.N.O."

Right. In today's supposedly enlightened society we should be thinking in terms of getting rid of the work ethic once and for all. It's over; it's outdated; it's had its day. Work is a curse, a drag, a nuisance, a barrier that stands between us and what we really want to do. People who want the Right to Work are fools. They're asking only for the right to be exploited, the right to be treated as slaves by society's higher-ups. The right to be bought and sold in the marketplace. Is this really a desirable state of being? No, it is'nt. Not to me at any rate.

These days the newspapers are forever paying lip service to 'the plight of the unemployed'. Occasionally some character will kill himself because he cant find a job, thus providing even more fodder for the propaganda machine. According to the Guardian, jobless men are twice as likely to commit suicide than those in work. I find this attitude baffling but not particularly disturbing. If a man thinks his sole purpose in life is to work, he might as well kill himself, because he's as good as dead anyway.

Apparently, researchers have also noticed that jobless men are more likely to develop cancer than those in work. Cancer is a psychosomatic illness connected with frustration and lack of purpose. It seems that the ordinary working man has grown so accustomed to thinking of himself as a packhorse that his vital life forces break down as soon as he's made redundant, and his body begins to go rotten inside. (This is undoubtedly why so many elderly men drop dead soon after they retire; their sole reason for staying alive has been taken away from them.)

The Christmas edition of NME contained a brief 'seasonal message' from the Northern poetess Joolz. Predictably she felt obliged to wish all NME readers 'a tinsel Christmas and an EMPLOYED New Year.' This was supposed to demonstrate the extent of her social concern, but it did nothing of the sort. Instead it made her look like a right pratt. Dont be fooled, kids; we're never going to see a return to full employment. No political party can guarantee that. The unemployment figures may fluctuate now and then, but in the last analysis they're going to keep on rising higher and higher. They're bound to, simply because unemployment is the natural, healthy result of an advanced technological society.

Moreover, there's nothing wrong with unemployment at all. Infact, it's potentially a bloody good thing, because it provides people with an oppurtunity to escape from drudgery once and for all. Its only real drawback is that it leads to boredom on a massive scale - feelings of disaffilliation, riots and so forth. The way around this impasse is to teach people to enjoy their free time, and use it constructively. As Robert Anton Wilson wrote; "People can only spend so much time fucking, smoking dope and watching TV. After a while they get bored. This is the main psychological objection to a workless society, and the answer to it is to educate people for functions more cerebral then fucking, smoking dope and watching TV, or the idiot jobs that most are currently toiling at." Wilson believes that there should be "a massive increase investment in adult education." I can only agree.

The so-called 'work ethic' is coming apart at the seams like a rotten undervest. It has been since the '60s, when the hippies first began to challenge traditional ideas of work and leisure. As the technological revolution continues to accelerate, more and more men and women will be set free from their condition of 'wage slavery' (as the social critics call it). To accomodate them, it may be necessary to alter the whole structure of society. Get some bulldozers in here and clean out all this crap. The creation of a permanent 'unemployed class' would certainly be a step in the right direction, though whether or not it'll ever happen remains to be seen. It's all a question of priorities...

So ; If you're on the dole, make the most of it. And above all, dont be taken in by the 'Right to Work' propaganda of bands like Chelsea and the Redskins. It is, as the Americans say, a crock of shit. Oddly enough pig-ignorant Irish has-been Bob Geldof summed it all up a couple of years ago when he remarked that "All these wanky little bands like Chelsea, singing about the Right to Work, are totally off the wall." (If my memory serves me correctly, Geldof also said something about 'the dignity of labour' being redundant. These may well be the only intelligent comments he's ever made.) Make no mistake, a man who goes to work every day is as Marx said, 'a tool, an automaton.' A life on society's outer fringe is preferable to anything that smacks of responsibility. And that's a fact...PETE SCOTT 1/1/83

# SOME THOUGHTS ON WORK, TIME AND COMMUNITIES

> MADELEINE ELLIS-PETERSEN

From The Wealth Press: The Work and Time Issue

www.wealthequality.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/04/The-Wealth-Press-----Work-and-Time-Issuel.pdf

People in the UK work a lot. The UK tops the European long hours league and the number of people working over 48 hours a week in the UK has increased by 15% since 2010. Why do we work this much? And what happens to the other non-work aspects of our lives, when so much of our time is spent working?

The average full time worker in the UK spends about 38 hours a week working. When you factor in travel time, unpaid overtime (in 2015, more than five million people put in an average of 7.7 hours extra work a week in unpaid overtime), time thinking about work outside of work and time spent telling other people about our work, it becomes apparent that work takes up a great deal of our lives.

The impact of overwork on our mental and physical health has been extensively documented – last year, 9.9 million working days in the UK were lost to work related stress or anxiety. People that work more than 11 hours a day are 2.5 times more likely to develop depression and more than 60 times more likely to develop heart disease. But overwork also negatively affects the health of our communities, our relationships and our democracy. A world in which we spend a great deal of our time in paid work is also a world in which we have far less time to spend with those around us, participating in democracy, getting to know our neighbours or taking an active role in the world outside of work.

If the full-time norm became 30 hours or less, our communities could flourish. We'd have the time and energy to spend improving our local areas, time to organise and participate in community events and time to spend getting to know and caring for people around us. With more time, we might use local shops and markets more than big supermarkets, we might grow more of our own food and walk or cycle instead of drive. In short, we'd spend more time in our communities, rather than simply travelling through them, and our communities would flourish as a result.

< PETE SCOTT

Mission statement from Vague #14 (Facsimile reproduction)

v PRECARIOUS WORKERS BRIGADE

From teaching tool 'Bust Your Boss – a forum theatre workshop', in 'Training for Exploitation? Politicising Employability and Reclaiming Education', p.51–53.

www.joaap.org/press/pwb/PWB_Text_FINAL.pdf

## BUST YOUR BOSS!*

card for freelance art and cultural workers

During a negotiation about work you have the right:
**not** to remain silent about money
**not** to subsidise the production from your own pocket
**not** to accept a change of agreed conditions without a renegotiation
**not** to take this job on the promise of a future!

** Warning: In the cultural sector your boss may not look like a boss – they could be your friend/drinking buddy... It might even be you!*

In solidarity – Precarious Workers Brigade
www.precariousworkersbrigade.tumblr.com

## BUST YOUR BOSS!

YOU HAVE THE RIGHT TO ASK:

*What's the budget? How much am I getting paid? How much are YOU getting paid? When am I getting paid? Do I get paid sick leave and holidays? Will my pay cover a living wage for the period of the project? What union can I join? Are there separate budgets for production, expenses and pay? When shall we agree the terms of the contract? What is the compensation fee if the work gets cancelled? Has all the money for the project been raised? What is the maternity/paternity and pension provision? Where is the money for the project coming from and what degree of involvement do funders have in my work? etc..*

de zeenjobs

London, UK

## Part-I/II architecture assistant at RGSc Architects LLP

17 April 2017

**Architectural Assistant**
Clerkenwell, London, United Kingdom

RGSc Architects LLP is an award-winning residential practice, at the forefront of estate gentrification and housing architecture in London. Our busy architectural design studio in central London is looking for talented and ambitious Part I and Part-II architectural assistants to work on our medium to large scale housing and mixed-use projects in the UK.

We have exciting new schemes for a range of very specific clients including local authorities housing associations and developers. We work on projects for identikit high-density urban housing and high-density urban housing for suburban areas. You'll be involved at a menial level in transforming what are currently affordable neighbourhoods into elite enclaves for those who can pay.

We look for candidates who will work overtime on a regular basis without being paid; who will put their strong technical knowledge and design sensitivity to the test on exercises in repetitive foam modeling, tracing other assistants' drawings, and adjusting options for estate refurbishment so that demolition always looks the most convincing.

We offer a competitive salary starting at less than the London Living Wage, commensurate with your gender, experience, and residency status. Other perks include: occasional beers at the pub if you brown-nose the management team, constant reminders that those higher up in the office are buying houses in the latest area we're going to gentrify, and an annual office party with bad (probably racist) jokes about awkward moments with estate residents.

**Essential skills and qualification:**

- A passion for displacing the poor
- Cutting foam to exceptional precision
- Operate a photocopier/plotter/stapler
- Use a ring-binder under pressure
- Carrying models to and from meetings
- Be able to decipher cryptic instruction from your project architect
- Have exemplary software skills, in case we need them
- An unquestioning attitude

### How to apply

To apply please send a copy of your CV and example portfolio of your recent work (in PDF format and no more than 5MB) to info@rgsc-architects.co.uk

Please identify any professional trade union memberships you hold.

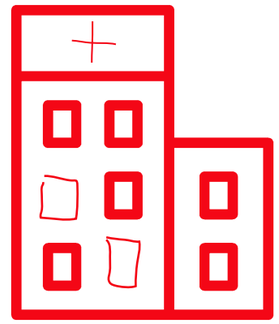
No agencies please. We only coerce the brightest young talent.

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v ARCHITECTURAL WORKERS
'Looking for your dream job?'
www.architecturalworkers.wordpress.com/2017/04/29/looking-for-your-dream-job/

# WORK TO RULE
## A Call for Strike Action in the Arts



v ROSALIE SCHWEIKER

Previously published in 'Let's Mobilize: What is Feminist Pedagogy?', Valand Academy, University of Gothenburg, Sweden.

www.dropbox.com/s/t8angkggaxv8yny/Let's%20Mobilize-workbook-screen.pdf?dl=0

On 27th August 2015, I signed a patient agreement to confirm that I'm fine about a consultant removing a benign lump from my left breast with a new, experimental method of High Intensity-Focused Ultrasound. The main reason why I signed up for this treatment was that I wanted some time off. I needed an excuse not to have to reply to emails or do anything for a few days. I wanted to be too sick to work. Ironically, this new smart non-invasive surgery worked so well that after 2 hours I was walking out of Guy's hospital, feeling totally fine, with a clear head and not in any kind of pain. I nevertheless spent the rest of the day in bed. But of course I checked my emails. I scrolled Facebook and Twitter. I got a text from one of my colleagues and replied. The next day, a day I had marked with 'sick leave' in my diary, I went to check some prints at the designers, spent 3 hours to clear my inbox, edited a press statement for an upcoming project, took a few phone calls and went for a walk to think about what I would do for this workshop. As a self-employed artist, I could actually take time off whenever I want. I am my own boss. But I am also a self-un-employed artist, so when there is work, I have to take it. And at the moment there is lots of work, which is badly paid but at least it's paid, so I feel like I can't decline it. This means that before my cunningly planned, yet badly executed sick leave, I did not have a day without doing some kind of art admin or art work for months. You might think that not having a single day without art is actually a good thing. Because, don't we all want great art for everybody all the time, everywhere? To me, being an artist is not some kind of higher calling that has been bestowed upon me at birth. I'm not an artist. I work as an artist. It is a job that I have chosen and for which I am constantly writing and re-writing the job description. My art work is work. It fulfills a function in society, just like any other profession. It needs to be seen as work, otherwise it has no impact and becomes a self-righteous pastime for those who can afford to engage with it. If I don't see it as work, I am dogging an issue, similarly to how seeing housework as unpaid labour has prevented the creation of an equal society. Compared to other professions, I think artists still have it easy. Plus, I have had a very happy childhood and my parents have always supported me. I am white, cis, heterosexual and therefore don't have to take much abuse and discrimination in my daily life. My English is quite good, so I don't even have to deal with being seen as a foreigner or migrant (at least not until the EU referendum). I have a home, clean water, enough food. I was allowed to vote in the Labour leadership elections. By all standards, I have an easy life. However, something is wrong. Somehow I felt I had to sign up for an experimental surgery to take a day off. And then I didn't even manage to take the day off. What's wrong? I shouldn't have to, as generations of women before me, submit to some kind of illness to have my needs met. Why do I have this incapability to switch off, let go, not give a fuck, be lazy, take some time out? It's not that I work 16 hours a day for Goldman Sachs in exchange for a 16-figure bonus. I've earned £1,000 this month. Why am I working a seven day week? Why do I care? I think part of this problem is that I work in the arts, which is the most capitalistic, rotten, bigoted industry there is. Imagine Amazon merging with the Cosa Nostra and Shell to frack in Antarctica, with the drill heads in the shape of David Cameron's penis – the culture sector is worse than that. It's fine if you're Greyson Perry, if you don't mind selling political pottery to rich people while becoming the chancellor of a university that sues its own students for protesting against cuts. But if you're not Greyson Perry, the art world is against you and however hard you try, you will have to get another job to make a living (which is not a bad thing in itself, it's just bad if your day job subsidises the art work you do for other people, who profit from not having to pay you properly). As the campaign group W.A.G.E. states, artists 'make the world more interesting'. And just like W.A.G.E. suggests, we should demand payment for it. But because of a systemic failure which is perpetuated by all of us, this demand for payment has yet to be met. Let's take for example this workshop. At the moment my hourly rate is £45. My day rate is £250. This is how much I think my time is worth. Obviously I don't get paid that much. And, as with a lot of messy jobs, it's hard to measure an artist's labour with the usual wage per hour ratio. If we started paying artists per hour, I think I would have already earned this workshop fee, just with the preparation, email negotiations etc. Because it's all so confusing and arbitrary anyway, I've just decided that the £150 fee (which I will split in half with my friend Maria for reasons I can explain later, so it's actually £75), equals 2 hours of my time. So I have 2 hours in which to prepare this workshop. I have sat down in front of my computer and set a timer to count 120 minutes. When it beeps I will stop working on this text. No matter where I am, no matter if it's good or bad. I will keep in all the typos and grammar errors, I will not ask my partner to edit and proofread it for me, I will not ask my designer friend to typeset it properly in exchange for buying her lunch. I will share the act of reading this text with you. I have been reading it aloud until now, in a minute I will stop and then it would be great if one of you could take over reading it aloud, until you get tired of hearing your own voice, and somebody else will take over. We can of course also read this in silence. Whatever suits you. So, when I went on this walk I mentioned earlier (to find out what I'd like to do with you today), an idea popped into my head. It is a quite simple idea but it might have big implications. I have come here today to ask you to join me in organising a strike. Actually, it won't be a proper strike, it will be a period of work-to-rule. I first came across the expression 'work-to-rule' when midwives demonstrated for a 1% pay rise in 2014. Work-to-rule is 'an industrial action in which employees do

no more than the minimum required by the rules of their contract, and precisely follow safety or other regulations in order to cause a slowdown, rather than to serve their purposes. Such an action is considered less disruptive than a strike or lockout; and just obeying the rules is less susceptible to disciplinary action', says Wikipedia. The midwives stopped working for free, stopped working overtime, stopped doing more than what was specified in their contract. This brought things to a halt. Because just like the arts, the NHS runs off our generous goodwill and manic helper syndrome. I'm suggesting a work-to-rule week for cultural workers. I'm suggesting a work-to-rule month for cultural workers. I'm suggesting a work-to-rule year for cultural workers. This work-to-rule strike would mean that:
You don't work if you are not paid.
If you are paid you're not putting in more than you are getting paid for (even if as a consequence, the work is shit).
You care about yourself not the institution, commissioner, funder. You meet regularly with other culture producers who work-to-rule to discuss your progress. You don't ask your friends or colleagues to do you 'a favour', but you pay people a decent day rate. You don't use social media (unless you are being paid to do so). If you work in a collective, you don't split the artist fee, but you demand a fee for each of you. You declare publicly to be part of the strike. I am sure there could be lots more conditions and rules. We can talk about this later. I know that there is more to life and work than money. Yes, money is not the only form of validation. But we all have to pay rent. We should all earn enough to pay taxes, to save for a pension, to support our families, to contribute to society (not just with our art). If you work for an arts institution, be it as a curator, administrator, artist, invigilator, bookshop sales assistant or cleaner, you should earn the living wage (currently £7.85/9.15). Why does this sound so radical? My immediate fear when I reread these initial outlines of the work-to-rule manifesto was that I would earn less money. Which is an absurd and irrational fear. Because I wouldn't have less money. I would have more time. Everything needs to be changed, organised completely differently. If I worked to rule I would have more head space. If I worked to rule I would find more joy in my work, because the strict time limits for each task would give me agency to improvise, to make mistakes, to sketch. If I worked to rule I would feel less isolated as an artist and part of a wider movement. If I worked to rule I would have more time to make the art, events, gatherings, activities that I truly want to do. If I worked to rule I would have more time to be with my family and friends. But what about organising the work-to-rule strike, would that not take lots of our time and be unpaid? Ah, crap.
Gustav Metzger's art strike manifesto: 'The refusal to labour is the chief weapon of workers fighting the system; artists can use the same weapon.
To bring down the art system it is necessary to call for years without art, a period of three years – 1977 to 1980 – when artists will not produce work, sell work, permit work to go on exhibitions, and refuse collaboration with any part of the publicity machinery of the art world. This total withdrawal of labour is the most extreme collective challenge that artists can make to the state. The years without art will see the collapse of many private galleries. Museums and cultural institutions handling contemporary art will be severely hit, suffer loss of funds, and will have to reduce their staff. National and local government institutions will be in serious trouble. Art magazines will fold'. He wrote this in 1974. I am not saying: don't do any more art. I am saying: don't make more art for less. Arts funding is being cut, so why do we keep pretending it isn't? If, as an arts organisation, you can't pay more than a £50 fee for an artist's contribution to a panel discussion, maybe don't do a fucking panel discussion. Have a rethink! The Arts Council sees less output as a sign that an organisation is in trouble – maybe organise a protest outside the ACE office. Less is more.
From Barry Sykes' text in his Book Works book: 'My concern is how all these arts organisations are trying to generate as much output as possible with even more modest means and the buck often stopping with the plucky, ambitious artist eager for exposure and willing to take the delayed gratification. And I feel like every time someone accepts or doesn't feel they can question conditions such as these it gets much harder for anyone else to expect any better, and gives no encouragement to arts organisations to make a change. So what am I doing still contributing?'. The other day I got an email from H, who I am working with at the moment on a project called *Some ideas for a new art institution*. H wrote: 'Hi Rosalie, Just a few thoughts/questions: 1. [...] 2. Sorry – My daughter woke up so gotta go so I will finish this email tomorrow!'. When I checked the header, she had written this to me at 11.36pm. Her email footer says she works 2.5 days, Wednesday pm and all day Thursday and Friday. I doubt that by 'all day Thursday and Friday' it means that she should be on duty 24hrs, but that's the reality, that's how much she and her colleagues work. And how you'd combine this work schedule with having children, let alone earn enough money to give yourself and these children a decent life is completely beyond me. I think there should be more moments of: 'My daughter woke up so gotta go'. A lot of cultural workers are women and we all work more than we get paid anyhow, because of the gender pay gap (data on pay gap, is it 1/3?). Maybe we need to just stop. What would happen if we all had a lie-in? Just stop. Sit down. Secretly sleeping on the toilet, with two loo rolls as a cushion. Write fewer emails, don't think in status updates. Use the time to lie in bed next to people, to make protest banners, to water the plants. *To call someone out* [phrasal verb of call] *1. summon someone to deal with an emergency or to do repairs. 2. order or advise workers to strike.* As part of the *Some ideas for a new art institution* project, I organised confidence workshops for women, which were run by Josie Sutcliffe. There were many amazing moments during these workshops, my favourite one being when a women recalled how she had been treated at her last job and concluded her story with 'I don't know why the fuck I let them get away with it'. Being assertive: No this can't be done until tomorrow. no, we can't deliver this project on the budget you are suggesting. No, we don't want to fly to Japan for a 20-minute talk. No, we can't book our own travel. You have to do it for us. No, we can't take the financial risk. You have to pay us in advance. Making bad art, because there isn't enough money to do good art. making good art, because you stopped pretending there is enough money.

Work-to-rule: what are the rules? This is getting a bit incoherent now. Thinking of Ana Laura Lopez de la Torre – when years ago in her studio in Brixton, she showed me her calendar. An A1 piece of paper, every project had a colour and she would mark how much time she had spent on each project on any given day. Is it the variety, the multi-tasking that makes it even harder to work-to-rule, because you never know when it starts or when it ends? If we really did this strike, would I have to give up doing the show for the Kunstverein, for which I am not getting a proper artists fee? But I'd really like to do this show, it would be so good to… Oh, 2 hours are up. The timer on my phone is beeping.

# Introduction to THE REFUSAL OF WORK: The Theory & Practice of Resistance to Work

v DAVID FRAYNE

from 'The Refusal of Work'(Zed Books 2015), p.1–5

*It's eight o'clock in the morning.*
*When you come out it will be dark.*
*The sun will not shine for you today.*



The above quotation is taken from Elio Petri's 1971 film *La classe operaia va in paradiso (The Working Class Goes to Heaven)*. The film gives a fictionalised account of the struggles of the Italian Autonomist movement: a loose coalition of students, workers, feminists and unemployed people who protested in Italy in the 1960s and 1970s. The quote is a slogan, shouted through a megaphone at eight o'clock in the morning and intended for the ears of the hundreds of workers who at that time were filing through the factory gates for another day of repetitive and hazardous labour. I quote it here as a perfect illustration of what the Autonomists were fighting for. Their cause went beyond the traditional union demands for fairer pay and better working conditions. They acknowledged the need for greater freedom and equality within work, but also fought for the right of workers to lead richer lives *outside* of work. The Autonomists protested at the wasted time, lack of variety, and excessive administration of life in capitalist society. They fought for the right of workers to feel the sun on their skin, to play with their children, to develop interests and skills outside the factory, and to rest peacefully at night. We might say that the appeal of the Autonomists was not just to the injustices of exploitation, but also to the worker's diminished sensory experience of the world.

Mirroring these concerns, a range of social critics (from the authors of the Frankfurt School to related critics such as André Gorz) have set out to question work from an emancipatory standpoint, supporting a vision of social progress based on a reduction of work and an expansion of free-time. These critics did not deny the importance of work, nor did they dismiss the many pleasures to be found in productive activity, but they did propose that a reduction of work might leave people with more time and energy for their own self-development. These critiques of work have provoked their readers by highlighting the casualties of a work-centred society: the time for politics, contemplation, conviviality and spontaneous enjoyment, which have been displaced by capitalism's narrow focus on commercial production and consumption. For today's students, who find themselves pushed through an education system focused largely on socialising the young for a future job role, to read these critiques is to receive an education in desire, and a reminder that time could be spent differently. The radical nature of these theories, however, has earned them a marginal position in academic and public debates. Whilst important issues like pay inequalities and poor working conditions are still discussed, it is rarer for social commentators to question the ethical status of work itself.

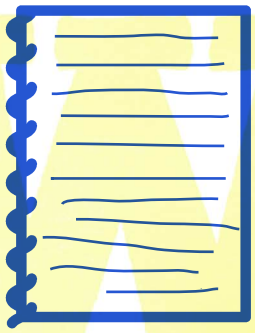
Whilst this is certainly true, the alternative vision of social development implied in calls for a less work-centred future has seen a modest resurgence in recent times. Go to any high-street bookshop and alongside those books promising to instruct readers on how to influence others, accumulate fortunes and achieve career success, one can also find a shelf of books telling readers to slow down, find a better 'work-life balance', and seek happiness by consuming less. In the context of contemporary capitalist societies, narrowly fixated as they are on the activities of working and spending, the ultimate message of these books is a valuable one, tapping into a rippling disquiet about the ways in which work has crept into and colonised our lives. If these popular critiques have ultimately had a limited influence on society's priorities, however, it is perhaps because they have tended to stray too far into the genre of self-help. Their mistake has been to approach the domination of work as primarily a problem of individual habits, and it is fair to say that these books have been rather more conservative when it comes to discussing those systemic economic and political changes which might offer people a more genuine range of lifestyle choices.

More promising than the stagnant discussion of 'work-life balance' is the emergence of a braver critique of the paradigm of economic growth. Conventionally, governments have treated economic growth and life satisfaction as one and the same thing, measuring both of these via the metric of gross domestic product (or GDP) per capita. GDP is an indicator which quantifies a country's overall economic activity. It accounts for the total amount of earning and spending that took place in a given year, and it is tacitly accepted that a rising level of GDP indicates an overall improvement in national prosperity. Whilst economic growth is undoubtedly crucial for less developed countries, in which subsistence needs remain unmet, a range of commentators in more affluent societies have questioned the value of GDP growth as a social goal and an index of progress.
A report commissioned in 2008 by the former French president Nicolas Sarkozy argues that 'the time is ripe for our measurement system to shift emphasis from measuring economic production to measuring people's well-being' (Stiglitz et al., 2010). The report stresses, among other things, the important role for human flourishing of health, education, relationships and the environment, and represents just one entry in a growing base of evidence to suggest that happiness, security and human progress will no longer flow in an unproblematic fashion from a growth in GDP (see Jackson, 2009).

This developing uneasiness about the equation of economic growth with life satisfaction has seen sociologists and even some economists returning to the fundamental philosophical question of what it means to live a good life. Critical commentators and the new sociologists of happiness are once again talking about the *ars vitae* or 'art of living', and this has inevitably led them to question whether our well-being is best served by capitalism's single-minded commitment to economic growth. Some have relied (not always convincingly, it must be said) on statistical measures of people's subjective well-being, whereas others have drawn inspiration from more philosophical sources. Aristotle's vision of the good life is a common reference point. Aristotle suggested that humans flourish when they live wisely, justly, and in harmony with the world. According to his notion of *eudaemonia*, a sense of well-being is achieved not simply through sensory pleasure, but also through things like good health, security, companionship, autonomy, a sense of being respected and socially recognised, and a feeling of connection with the community and environment. All these things are important because humans are ethical, social and creative beings, as well as sensing bodies. If the ongoing drive to boost economic growth has become troubling for many, this is partly because of its decidedly anti-Aristotelian fixation on material gain as the route to prosperity.

In an age of material abundance, it seems that there is a troubling disparity between our desire for the good life and capitalism's narrower focus on the constant expansion of production and consumption. What most people crave is more free-time and a greater investment in the social aspects of life, but a growing awareness of this fact has done very little to upset the mainstream political agenda. In the UK (the context in which I am writing), apart from the Labour Party's cursory interest in work–life balance in the mid 2000s, the question of working hours has generally disappeared from the agenda, replaced by a focus on employability and the cultivation of a workforce that will ensure the country's competitiveness in a global economy. The stripping back of the welfare state, which in recent times has seen a phased introduction of increasingly stringent penalties for the non-worker, has also significantly reduced the latitude for resistance to work. The ethical superiority of work seems almost untouchable. Paid jobs continue to be promoted as a vital source of good health and character, the media continues obsessively to demonise the non-working 'scrounger', and an old-fashioned work ethic maintains its anchorage in policies designed to force people off welfare and into employment.

## GLOSSARY & RESOURCES



### WORK-TO-RULE
Work-to-rule is an industrial action in which employees do no more than the minimum required by the rules of their contract, and precisely follow all safety or other regulations, which may cause a slowdown or decrease in productivity, as they are no longer working during breaks or during unpaid extended hours and weekends (checking email, for instance).

### TIME OFF IN LIEU
Employers giving their employees time off equal to overtime hours worked, instead of paying for these hours.

### WORKING TAX CREDIT
Working Tax Credit is designed to top up your earnings if you work and you're on a low income. For more information www.gov.uk/tax-credits-calculator.

### PRECARIAT
In sociology and economics, the precariat is a social class formed by people suffering from precarity, which is a condition of existence without predictability or security, affecting material or psychological welfare.

### DOMESTIC LABOUR
A concept developed within feminist theory to analyse the significance of the unpaid work performed by women in the home. Domestic labour has four main components: housework, support work, status production, and child care.

### EMOTIONAL LABOUR
The process of managing feelings and expressions to fulfill the emotional requirements of a job or a relationship. More specifically, workers are expected to regulate their emotions during interactions with customers, co-workers and superiors.

### FREELANCE
A freelancer or freelance worker is a term commonly used for a person who is self-employed and is not necessarily committed to a particular employer long-term.

### INTERN
A student or trainee who works, sometimes without pay, in order to gain work experience or satisfy requirements for a qualification.

### CO-OPERATIVE
An autonomous association of persons united voluntarily to meet their common economic, social, and cultural needs and aspirations through a jointly-owned and democratically-controlled enterprise. For more info visit www.uk.coop/about/what-co-operative.

## EMPLOYMENT TRIBUNAL
A tribunal is a public body responsible for hearing claims from people who think someone such as an employer or potential employer has treated them unlawfully. For more info visit www.gov.uk/courts-tribunals/employment-tribunal.

## BOOKS

David Frayne, *The Refusal of Work: The Theory and Practise of Resistance to Work* (Zed Books 2015)

Jonathan Crary, *24/7: Late Capitalism and the End of Sleep* (Verso Books 2015)

Precarious Workers Brigade, *Training for Exploitation? Politicising Employability and Reclaiming Education* (Journal of Aesthetics & Protest Press 2017)

Joanna Biggs, *All Day Long: A Portrait of Britain At Work* (Serpent's Tail 2015)

Nick Srnicek & Alex Williams, *Inventing the Future: Postcapitalism and a World Without Work* (Verso Books 2015)

e-flux Journal, *Are You Working Too Much? Post-Fordism, Precarit, and the Labour of Art* (Sternberg Press 2011)

Silvia Federici, *Revolution at Point Zero: Housework, Reproduction, and Feminist Struggle* (PM Press/Common Notions 2012)

Ivan Illich, *The right to useful unemployment* (Marion Boyars 1978)

Ross Perlin, *Intern Nation: How to Earn Nothing and Learn Little in the Brave New* (Verso Books 2012)


## ARTICLES

Isabell Lorey, *Prevarication, indebtedness, giving time* www.chisenhale.org.uk/images/exhibitions/Maria_Eichhorn_5_weeks,_25_days,_175_hours_Chisenhale_Gallery_2016.pdf

Liam Gillick, *The Good of Work* www.e-flux.com/journal/16/61277/the-good-of-work

George Woodcock, *The Tyranny of the Clock* www.spunk.org/texts/writers/woodcock/sp001734.html

David Chandler, *All Work and No Pay: creative industries freelancers are exploited* www.theguardian.com/small-business-network/2017/may/18/all-work-and-no-pay-creative-industries-freelancers-are-exploited

Allan Yu, *Failures* www.allanyu.nyc/2017/01/10/failures.html

Martha Rosler, *Why Are People Being So Nice?* www.e-flux.com/journal/77/76185/why-are-people-being-so-nice

Silvio Lorusso, *What is the Entreprecariat?* www.networkcultures.org/entreprecariat/what-is-the-entreprecariat/

David Graeber, *On the phenomenon of bullshit jobs.* www.libcom.org/library/phenomenon-bullshit-jobs-david-graeber


## RESOURCES
Demand a 4 Day Week
Campaigning for a shorter working week for all. www.4dayweek.co.uk

AltGen
Young people's co-operative agency based in London. www.altgen.coop

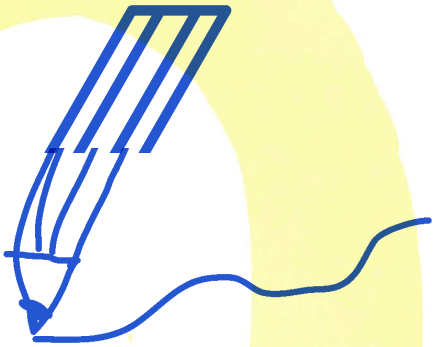
Graphic design (unpaid) internship
Collecting information about graphic design companies and how much they pay their interns, submitted anonymously. www.unpaid.life

Precarity Pilot
Resource dealing with issues faced by precarious designers. www.precaritypilot.net

New Economics Foundation
www.neweconomics.org

Wealth Equality
www.wealthequality.org

Add more to this resource list
goo.gl/Tm1Zqp




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